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SOME THINGS, THEY say, are made for each other. Like cricket and Indian fans; peanut butter and chocolate; or smartphones and social media. Now add one more to the mix—Snapchat and India's young population.

Asia is home to the world's youngest population, while the core target for the multimedia messaging platform developed by Snap Inc. is the 13-34 age group; and India has a growing population in that particular demographic, and according to experts, is still an underpenetrated market in terms of social media. And India's community of Snapchatters—those who use the platform—is growing. Snap, which had entered the country in 2019, announced last year that it had crossed the milestone of more than 200 million monthly active users. What is of note is that “almost all of that growth has taken place in 2-2.5 years in the face of very intense competition” says Ajit Mohan, the company's President (Asia Pacific), sitting in the company's low-key office at Mumbai's Bandra Kurla Complex. Snap reported that its operating revenue from the India operations

doubled from ₹32.7 crore in FY21 to ₹65.78 crore in FY22, according to data from the Registrar of Companies and business research platform Tofler.

And the future, say analysts, looks promising for Snap in India. “There is the large demographic of a young population and that aligns nicely with Snap's target segment. That means a large part of the next wave for Snap will come from markets such as India,” says Neil Shah, Research Vice President and Partner at Counterpoint Research, a global tech industry research firm. The engagement of this audience took off with TikTok in the pre-pandemic phase, before it was banned by the Indian government. “It was later replaced by Instagram and Snapchat. Not only did we see more users moving to Snap, but also a growing community of content creators, influencers, developers and media partners flocking to these platforms,” he adds.

While a clear definition of the demographics and Snap's expertise in augmented reality (AR), have helped grow the user base, an India-specific strategy is gathering momentum. Mohan, who has had stints with Disney and Meta, says the focus is on growing the business and not missing the opportunity in the country.

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IN THE WORLD of social media, an idea needs to not just be unique but must have the ability to scale up and be relevant. That is quite a task and innovation can make or break a product. Mohan would know. After all, he wit-



“Growth has taken place in a short period and a lot of effort has been on shaping the product... We have not done enough to build the business and that is now a big focus area”

AJIT MOHAN

PRESIDENT, ASIA-PACIFIC, SNAP INC.